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1931, ‘I Will Climb the Gallows Gladly’

By the end of his trial before the special tribunal, Bhagat Singh wished to die. Of that there can be no doubt. In his last letter to his father shortly before he was hanged, he even upbraided his own father for getting in the way. Kishan Singh had made a last-ditch frantic plea by writing to the tribunal on 20 September 1930 from Bradlaugh Hall in Lahore. He had claimed that his son was innocent of J.P. Saunder’s murder because, ‘Bhagat Singh was in Calcutta on the day of the occurrence and he actually wrote and despatched a letter . . .’ from there. In fact, there were witnesses and ‘I can produce them if I am given an opportunity, according to justice, or they may be called as court witnesses in the interest of justice, equity and good conscience’ because ‘[t]he question in this case is of life and death’.[1] Bhagat Singh was incensed. Far from even putting up a defence he had never been interested in even proving his innocence. In a letter to his father which he asked to be made public and which was published in *The Tribune* on 4 October 1930,[2] he scolded his father in the sternest terms. He wrote how ‘from the very beginning you have been trying to convince me to fight my case very seriously and to defend myself properly’ but that ‘you also know that I was opposed to it’. The reason was that ‘we have been pursuing a definite policy in this trial’. This being so, ‘[e]very action of mine ought to have been consistent with that policy, my principle and my programme’, clearly demonstrating how his approach to the trial was elaborately conceived and meticulously carried out from beginning to end. As he explained,

> I had only one idea before me throughout the trial, i.e. to show complete indifference towards the trial in spite of the serious nature of the charges against us. I have always